THE LIFE OF JESUS CHRIST

A FEATURED DEVOTIONAL

THE AUTHOR OF SALVATION

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“And being made perfect, he became the author of eternal salvation unto all them that obey him.”

HEBREWS 5:9

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Every Story Points to Him

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> *"Search the scriptures; for in them ye think ye have eternal life: and they are they which testify of me."*
>
> JOHN 5:39

Brother J. M. Hammon said:

"Our Father in Heaven is a man like we are, who has perfected Himself in His character and in His attributes and has qualified Himself to preside over the dominions of the earth. I believe His Son was born literally in the earth, the son of Mary. I believe they are two separate entities with one purpose. I believe that God is of such a character that we can have faith in Him and can approach Him and can expect some sympathy for our earthly problems and our mortal characters."[1]

I begin with Brother J. M. Hammon because we get to work with his son, Brother Hammon. And this year we are studying the relationship between Father and Son. Jesus said a son learns his work by watching his father. In John 5:19, Christ says:

"The Son can do nothing of himself, but what he seeth the Father do: for what things soever he doeth, these also doeth the Son likewise."[2]

Brother Jedd Hammon has taught us that one of the adversary's first attacks is against our understanding of the Adam–God doctrine.[3] Because if we lose sight of who our Father is, we begin to lose sight of who we are, and what we're meant to become. That warning is where my assigned title begins: Jesus Christ, the Author of Salvation.

Hebrews 5:8–9 tells us: "Though he were a Son, yet learned he obedience by the things which he suffered; and being made perfect, he became the author of eternal salvation unto all them that obey him."[4]

The Greek word here is *aitios*, meaning cause or source.[5] Jesus didn't write the story of salvation. That's the Father's eternal plan. Moses 1:39 tells us: "For behold, this is my work and my glory, to bring to pass the immortality and eternal life of man."[6] Immortality means a resurrection, and the Father couldn't give His children a resurrection without a sacrifice for them. He needed His Son. Near the end of His mortal ministry, Christ could say to His Father, "I have finished the work which thou gavest me to do."[7] I have finished the work. That's how He became the cause, the source, of our salvation.

Let's be honest about something. We're a little snobbish when it comes to the Old Testament. We tend to treat the New Testament as where the real gospel begins, and the Old Testament as some other thing that came before it. Like it's just background information before we get to the good stuff.

Maybe that's because we've heard these stories all our lives. Abraham and Isaac. Joseph in Egypt. Moses and the Passover. David and Goliath. We know how these stories end.

Jesus didn't read them that way. In John 5, He tells the people arguing with Him, "Search the scriptures; for in them ye think ye have eternal life: and they are they which testify of me."[8] And then, "Had ye believed Moses, ye would have believed me: for he wrote of me."[9] Imagine that. Their scriptures were the Old Testament, and Jesus is standing there telling them, those books are about Me.

One of the earliest examples is Adam. In Moses 5, he's commanded to offer the firstlings of his flock, and he does. Then "after many days,"[10] an angel shows up and asks him why he's offering sacrifices. Adam answers:

"I know not, save the Lord commanded me."[11]

I would have asked the angel where he'd been. This is one of several reasons I'm glad the story is about Adam.

Was that blind faith? Look at the verse. "After many days." Adam had done this for a long time with no explanation. This wasn't a stranger giving him orders. He'd walked and talked with God. He trusted the One who commanded him. And the explanation came because he kept going. The

angel then told him his sacrifice was "a similitude of the sacrifice of the Only Begotten of the Father."[12]

We make decisions and take risks every day without knowing exactly where the road is going to lead. Adam's trust rested on someone he knew.

Now remember who Adam is. Our Father in Heaven came to this earth and became Adam, the first man. The man kneeling at that altar, offering a lamb in similitude of the Only Begotten of the Father, was the Father Himself. Long before His Son was born, the Father was acting out His Son's sacrifice in mortality, keeping a commandment He didn't yet understand. When Jesus says the Son does what He sees the Father do, He's describing something true from the beginning. The Son learned obedience by the things which He suffered, and His Father had learned obedience on this earth first.

Then take Joseph of Egypt.

Joseph was a beloved son, long awaited and loved of his father, betrayed and rejected by his own brothers. They stripped him of his coat, sold him into slavery, and left him to suffer the consequences of their choices.[13]

He was falsely accused, repeatedly, imprisoned and forgotten. Through it all, he stayed true to God and eventually rose to tremendous authority in Egypt.[14]

Years later, famine brought Joseph's brothers to Egypt, desperate for food and unaware that the man standing before them was the brother they'd betrayed.[15]

Joseph tested them, and when Judah offered himself as a servant in place of their youngest brother, Joseph could no longer contain himself.[16]

He wept and revealed his identity: "I am Joseph your brother."[17]

He could have condemned them. Instead, he forgave them. His brothers had come expecting judgment. They were completely unprepared to be loved.

Think about the Savior. A beloved Son, sent by His Father. Rejected by His own, betrayed by someone close to Him, stripped of His clothing, falsely accused, made to suffer at the hands of the very people He came to save. Like Joseph, He could have condemned them. Instead, hanging on the cross,

He looked at the people responsible for His suffering and said, "Father, forgive them; for they know not what they do."[18]

Joseph saved his brothers from starvation. Christ saves us from death itself.

And how often do we find ourselves standing where those brothers stood? In need of something we can't provide for ourselves, and sometimes not recognizing just how completely we depend on Him. Joseph told them, "Ye thought evil against me; but God meant it unto good."[19] God can take even the worst things human beings do and bring something exalting out of them.

Ruth's story might be my favorite. She wasn't an Israelite. She was from Moab, and the law of Moses did not allow Moabites into the congregation of the Lord.[20] She'd married into a Bethlehem family, and after her husband died, her mother-in-law, Naomi, told her to return to her own people.[21] Have you ever heard the Brethren say that if the Priesthood ever tries to shake you off their back, you'd better hang on even tighter? That's essentially what was happening here. Naomi told her to leave, that she didn't belong with the Israelite people anymore. Ruth said no. "Whither thou goest, I will go; and where thou lodgest, I will lodge: thy people shall be my people, and thy God my God."[22] She chose the God of Israel with nothing to gain and nobody to protect her. Ruth couldn't have known she was on her way into the genealogy of Jesus.

Ruth ended up in Bethlehem gathering leftover barley in the fields of Boaz.[23] He blessed her, praying that she would find shelter under God's wings.[24] Later, Ruth asked Boaz to spread his garment over her.[25] The Hebrew word for garment is the same word used for wings.[26] Boaz had prayed she'd find shelter under God's wings, and Ruth essentially said, then you be that shelter.

And he did. Boaz became her *go'el*—her redeemer.[27] He paid the price to restore her family's future and brought Ruth, an outsider, into Israel. Centuries later, Christ would say, "How often would I have gathered thy children together, even as a hen gathereth her chickens under her wings."[28]

He came to bring in people who had been on the outside. Praising a Roman centurion's faith, He said, "many shall come from the east and west, and

shall sit down with Abraham, and Isaac, and Jacob, in the kingdom of heaven."[29] Ruth came in that same way centuries before. Her son Obed was King David's grandfather.[30] Matthew names only a handful of women in Jesus's genealogy. Ruth the Moabite is one of them.[31]

I think we sometimes imagine that everything pointing to Christ must be grandiose or dramatic. But consider Elijah.

He'd just confronted the prophets of Baal on Mount Carmel and watched fire come down from heaven.[32] Then he was running for his life again, this time from Queen Jezebel.[33] He was exhausted and, frankly, ready to give up. He sat down beneath a tree and said, "It is enough; now, O Lord, take away my life."[34] I have had thoughts about my entire future that should probably have waited until after lunch.

God sent an angel with food and water. Elijah ate. He slept. And then the angel came again and told him to eat some more, "because the journey is too great for thee."[35]

Elijah then traveled forty days into the wilderness, sustained by the food the angel had given him.[36] And centuries later, Christ Himself would spend forty days in the wilderness, hungry, tempted, and tested.[37] And when His trial was over, Matthew tells us that angels came and ministered to Him, just as an angel had ministered to Elijah.[38]

Sometimes we need a God who can part the Red Sea. Sometimes we need a God who can conquer death. And sometimes we need a God who understands that we're exhausted, that we're human, and that before we can face one more thing, we need a nap and a snack.

The Father who understood Elijah's weakness sent a Son who'd be hungry and tired in the wilderness Himself. He knows our weakness, and He helps us. That's the sympathy Brother J. M. Hammon said we could expect for our earthly problems and our mortal characters.

When I was in the Academy, Brother Hammon used to come back to a phrase we hear so often in our hymns and scriptures: "He is not here. He is risen."[39]

And he'd ask us, "What does that mean?!"

It means the gospel is true!

The tomb is empty, and Christ overcame death. Everything the Father promised, everything those ancient stories were pointing toward, came to be. He accomplished it.

My testimony is that Jesus Christ has made Himself known to me through His servants.

The Priesthood Council have guided me carefully through the most crucial stages of my life. They've taught me, like Adam, to have faith even when I don't understand why I'm being asked to do something.

Like Joseph, they've taught me to endure suffering I didn't choose, trust that God can bring good from circumstances I never wanted, and find the strength to forgive. Like Ruth, to remain faithful when the future is uncertain, trusting that the things that have been lost can be restored.

And like Elijah, to keep going when I'm exhausted, discouraged, or wondering whether I have anything left to give, and remember that sometimes the most faithful thing I can do is accept a little help, get some rest, and try again tomorrow.

I pray that we'll open these old stories looking for Him, and find in them the Son who did what He saw His Father do. In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

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1. J. Marion Hammon, remarks at a general meeting, Salt Lake City, Utah, September 17, 1959.
2. John 5:19.
3. See Brigham Young, April 9, 1852, Journal of Discourses 1:50–51.
4. Hebrews 5:8–9.
5. Greek *aitios*, "cause" or "source"; the King James Version renders it "author."
6. Moses 1:39.
7. John 17:4.
8. John 5:39.
9. John 5:46.
10. Moses 5:5–6.
11. Moses 5:6.
12. Moses 5:7.
13. See Genesis 37:3–28.
14. See Genesis 39–41.
15. See Genesis 42:1–8.
16. See Genesis 44:18–45:1.
17. Genesis 45:4.
18. Luke 23:34.
19. Genesis 50:20.
20. See Deuteronomy 23:3.
21. See Ruth 1:3–15.
22. Ruth 1:16.
23. See Ruth 2:1–3.
24. See Ruth 2:12.
25. See Ruth 3:9.
26. The Hebrew is *kanaph*, "wing" or the edge of a garment; the King James Version reads "skirt."
27. Hebrew *go'el*, the kinsman-redeemer, translated "near kinsman" in the King James Version. See Ruth 3:12–13; 4:1–10.
28. Matthew 23:37.
29. Matthew 8:11.
30. See Ruth 4:13–17.
31. See Matthew 1:5.
32. See 1 Kings 18:20–40.
33. See 1 Kings 19:1–3.
34. 1 Kings 19:4.
35. 1 Kings 19:7.
36. See 1 Kings 19:8.
37. See Matthew 4:1–11.
38. See Matthew 4:11.
39. See Matthew 28:6; Luke 24:6.